that provides additional information, such as the reasoning used or the policies that determined the decision.

- **Satisfied Policies** are the set of policies whose conditions match the context of the authorization request. These policies are considered during evaluation and can influence the decision. However, not all satisfying policies ultimately determine the outcome.
- **Determining Policies**—the specific policies that directly influenced the outcome of an authorization decision. These are the rules that caused the system to return either `allow` or `deny`. Determining policies are a subset of satisfying policies—they not only matched the request, but also played a decisive role in producing the result.

These terms may seem somewhat dry at first glance, but they form the foundation for everything that follows. Figure 4.1 shows the relationships between some of these terms. Whether you're writing policies, designing a system, or simply trying to understand how someone gained access to something they shouldn't have, having a clear and shared vocabulary makes a significant difference.

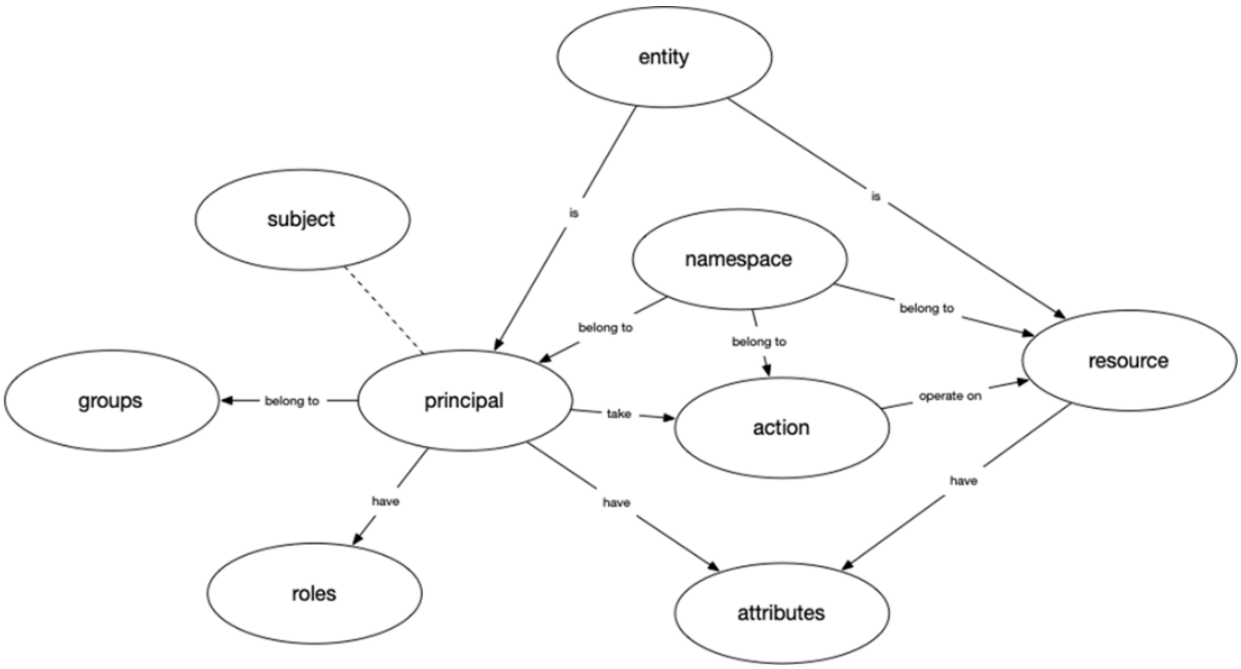


Figure 4.1 Relationships among key authorization terms. Principals, actions, and resources form the core of access decisions and are enriched with attributes, roles, and group memberships. All entities exist within namespaces and can be either principals or resources. The diagram also shows the legacy term subject as an older equivalent of principal and illustrates how actions operate on resources based on contextual and identity-based properties.